

BEDO0001: PHYSICAL EDUCATION & YOGA

Objective: Students will learn the introduction of Physical Education, the Concept of fitness and wellness, Weight management and the lifestyle of an individual. The student will also learn about the relationship of Yoga with mental health and value education. In this course, students will also learn about the aspects of the Traditional games of India.

Module No.	Content
	1. Physical Education: Meaning, Aim, Need, Importance and Scope of Physical Education in the Modern Society. Physical Education in India before and after Independence. 2. Concept of Fitness and Wellness: Meaning, Importance, and Factors affecting Fitness and Wellness. Components and fitness equipment. 3. Weight Management: Meaning, Factor affecting weight management. BMI: (Body mass index) Meaning, charts, range and category. Obesity: Meaning, Causes and its types, Solutions for Overcoming Obesity. 4. Lifestyle: Meaning, Definition, Importance, Factor affecting Lifestyle. Healthy Lifestyle through Diet. Relationship between Diet and Fitness. 5. Yoga and Meditation: Definition, importance of Yoga. Yoga relation with mental health and sports. Definition of Asana and Pranayama, differences between Asana and physical exercise. Asana-Suraya- Namaskar, Bhujang Asana, Naukasana, Halasana,Vajrasana, Padmasana, Shavasana, Makrasana, Dhanurasana, TadAsana. Pranayam - Anulom, Vilom, Bhramary. 6. Traditional Games of India: Meaning, types and benefits of Traditional Games. 7. Recreation in Physical Education: Meaning, Importance, and Benefits of Recreation. Types of Recreational Activities, Aerobics and Zumba (Fit India Movement).

Chapter No- 5

YOGA AND MEDITATION

1. Definition of yoga
2. Importance of yoga
3. Yoga relation with mental health and sports
4. Definition of Asana and Pranayama
5. Differences between Asana and Physical Exercise
6. Asana - Surya Namaskar, Bhujang Asana, Naukasana, Halasana, Vajrasana, Padmasana, Shavasana, Makrasana, Dhanurasana, Tad Asana.
7. Pranayam, -Anulom, Vilom, Bhramary.

1. Definition of yoga

“Yoga Karmasu Kaushalam”

“योग कर्मसु कौशलम्”

(Given by Lord Shri Krishna, Bhagvad Gita, Gita 2/50,)

“Yoga Cittavarttinirodha”

“योगश्चित्तवृत्तिनिरोधः”

Yoga is the Cessation of the whirlpools of the subconscious mind

(Given by Maharishi Patanjali, Yoga Sutra, Samadhi Pada, I: 2,)

“Manah Prashamanah Upayah Yoga Ityabhidhiyate”

“मनः प्रशमनः उपायः योग इत्यभिधीयते”

The Yoga-Vasishta

Raja yoga (Maharishi Patanjali)

Although Raja yoga traditionally emphasizes meditation as the path to self-realization, the term has come to refer to a much wider variety of practices. In the 19th century text Raja Yoga Swami Vivekananda equated Raja yoga with the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali. As such, Raja yoga has since been used interchangeably with Ashtanga yoga, or the ‘eightfold path’ to spiritual liberation.

According to Raja yoga, the biggest obstacle to self-realization is a busy mind, in which excessive thinking, ego, craving, attachment and a separate sense of self all contribute towards suffering.

Working through the mind and body practices outlined in Patanjali's eight limbs of yoga is believed to bring the practitioner close to an enlightened state of consciousness known as samadhi, in which it is possible to experience the true self.

The eightfold path or the eight limbs of Raja yoga are:

- 1. Yamas** - Five social observances: ahimsa (non-violence), satya (truthfulness) asteya (nonstealing), brahmacharya (chastity) and aparigraha (non-possessiveness).
- 2. Niyamas** - Five moral observances: saucha (purity), santosha (contentment), tapas (selfdiscipline), svadhyaya (self-study), ishvarapranidhana (devotion or surrender).
- 3. Asana** - Yoga postures.
- 4. Pranayama** - Breathing techniques as a means of controlling prana (vital life force energy).
- 5. Pratyahara** - Withdrawal of the senses.
- 6. Dharana** - Concentration.
- 7. Dhyana** - Meditation.
- 8. Samadhi** - Enlightenment or bliss.

These eight limbs offer a systematic approach to calming the mind and finding liberation from suffering. Raja yoga is ultimately a means of transcending identification with the body-mind-intellect complex in order to understand the nature of the true self.

2. Importance of yoga

Yoga is the science of right living and, as such, is intended to be incorporated in daily life. It works on all aspects of the person: the physical, vital, mental, emotional, psychic and spiritual. The word yoga means 'unity' or 'oneness' and is derived from Sanskrit yuj which means 'to join.' This unity or joining is described in spiritual terms as the union of the individual consciousness with the universal consciousness. On a more practical level, yoga is a means of balancing and harmonizing the body, mind and emotions. This is done through the practice of asana, pranayama, mudra, bandha, shatkarma and meditation, and must be achieved before union can take place with the higher reality. The science of yoga begins to work on the outermost aspect of the personality, the physical body, which for most people is a practical and familiar starting point. When imbalance is experienced at this level, the organs, muscles and nerves no longer function in harmony, rather they act in opposition, to each other. For instance, the endocrine system might become irregular and the efficiency of the nervous system decrease to such an extent that a disease will manifest. Yoga aims at

bringing the different bodily functions into perfect coordination so that they work for the good of the whole body.

From the physical body, yoga moves on to the mental and emotional levels. Many people suffer from phobias and neuroses as a result of the stresses and interactions of everyday living. Yoga cannot provide a cure for life but it does present a proven method for coping with it. Swami Sivananda of Rishikesh explained yoga as an “integration and harmony between thought, word and deed, or integration between head, heart and hand.” Through the practices of yoga, awareness develops of the interrelation between the emotional, mental and physical levels; and how a disturbance in any one of these affects the others. Gradually, this awareness leads to an understanding of the more subtle areas of existence. There are many branches of yoga: raja, hatha, jnana, karma, bhakti, mantra, kundalini and laya, to name but a few, and many texts explain them in detail. Each individual needs to find those yogas most suited to his/her particular personality and need. In the last half of this century, hatha yoga has become the most well-known and widely practiced of the systems. However, the concept of what constitutes yoga is broadening as more people take it up, and this knowledge is spreading. In the ancient texts, hatha yoga consists of the shatkarmas, cleansing practices, only. Today, however, hatha yoga commonly embraces the practices of asana, pranayama, mudra and bandha as well.

Yoga brings the body and mind together and is built on three main elements movement, breathing and meditation. Yoga has many physical and mental health benefits including improved posture, flexibility, strength, and balance and body awareness.

The main goals of “Yoga in Daily Life” are:

- Physical Health
- Mental Health
- Social Health
- Spiritual Health
- Self-Realization or Realization of the Divine within us.

These goals are attained by- Love and help for all living beings, a peaceful state of mind, pure thoughts and positive lifestyle etc.

- Mental benefits
- Heightened Concentration
- Strength & Flexibility
- Discipline and Mindfulness in Life
- Yoga helps with back pain relief

- Yoga benefits heart health
- Yoga relaxes you, to help you Sleep well
- Yoga can mean more energy and Brighter moods

3. Yoga relation with mental health and sports

Yoga can have many positive effects on mental health and sports, including:

- **Stress reduction:** Yoga can help athletes feel less stressed and anxious. It can also help athletes who are prone to overexertion.
- **Improved sleep:** Yoga can help athletes get restful sleep.
- **Enhanced focus:** Yoga can help athletes improve their focus and pay attention to their breathing.
- **Increased mindfulness:** Yoga can help athletes improve their mindfulness.
- **Better psychological flexibility:** Yoga can help athletes improve their psychological flexibility.
- **Slowed aging process:** Yoga can help slow the natural aging process by reducing brain shrinkage in areas that process information and store memories.
- **Better concentration**
- **Breathing control power**
- **Power of mindfulness state etc.**

4. Definition of Asana and Pranayama

Definition of Asana

Sthira Sukham Asanam

स्थिरसुखमासनम् || 46 || (Given by Maharishi Patanjali)

The Meaning of Sthira Sukham Asanam

Sthira – Steady,

Sukha – comfortable,

Asanam – is asana.

So, the sutra literally states that steady and comfortable is an asana. Often you will read the explanation as ‘steady, comfortable pose is asana.’ But here is exactly where the interpretation mistake happens: In the original (literal) translation, there is no mention of ‘pose’ in the definition.

The third limb of yoga is asana or posture. Asana brings steadiness, health and lightness of limb. A steady and pleasant posture produces mental equilibrium and prevents

fickleness of mind. Asanas are not merely gymnastic exercises; they are postures. To perform them one needs a clean airy place, a blanket and determination, while for other systems of physical training one needs large playing fields and costly equipment. Asanas can be done alone, as the limbs of the body provide the necessary weights and counter-weights. By practising them one develops agility, balance, endurance and great vitality. Asanas have been evolved over the centuries so as to exercise every muscle, nerve and gland in the body. They secure a fine physique, which is strong and elastic without being muscle-bound and they keep the body free from disease. They reduce fatigue and soothe the nerves. But their real importance lies in the way they train and discipline the mind.

Many actors, acrobats, athletes, dancers, musicians and sportsmen also possess superb physiques and have great control over the body, but they lack control over the mind, the intellect and the Self. Hence they are in disharmony with themselves and one rarely comes across a balanced personality among them. They often put the body above all else. Though the yogi does not underrate his body, he does not think merely of its perfection but of his senses, mind, intellect and soul.

The yogi conquers the body by the practice of asanas and makes it a fit vehicle for the spirit. He knows that it is a necessary vehicle for the spirit. A soul without a body is like a bird deprived of its power to fly.

The yogi does not fear death, for time must take its toll of all flesh. He knows that the body is constantly changing and is affected by childhood, youth and old age. Birth and death are natural phenomena but the soul is not subject to birth and death. As a man casting off worn-out garments takes on new ones, so the dweller within the body casting aside worn-out bodies enters into others that are new.

The yogi believes that his body has been given to him by the Lord not for enjoyment alone, but also for the service of his fellow men during every wakeful moment of his life. He does not consider it his property. He knows that the Lord who has given him his body will one day take it away.

The yogi believes that his body has been given to him by the Lord not for enjoyment alone, but also for the service of his fellow men during every wakeful moment of his life. He does not consider it his property. He knows that the Lord who has given him his body will one day take it away. By performing asanas, the sadhaka first gains health, which is not mere existence. It is not a commodity which can be purchased with money. It is an asset to be gained by sheer hard work. It is a state of complete equilibrium of body, mind and spirit. Forgetfulness of physical and mental consciousness is health. The yogi frees himself from

physical disabilities and mental distractions by practising asanas. He surrenders his actions and their fruits to the Lord in the service of the world.

The yogi realises that his life and all its activities are part of the divine action in nature, manifesting and operating in the form of man. In the beating of his pulse and the rhythm of his respiration, he recognises the flow of the seasons and the throbbing of universal life. His body is a temple which houses the Divine Spark. He feels that to neglect or to deny the needs of the body and to think of it as something not divine, is to neglect and deny the universal life of which it is a part. The needs of the body are the needs of the divine spirit which lives through the body. The yogi does not look heaven-ward to find God for he knows that He is within, being known as the Antaratma (the Inner Self). He feels the kingdom of God within and without and finds that heaven lies in himself. Where does the body end and the mind begin? Where does the mind end and the spirit begin? They cannot be divided as they are inter-related and but different aspects of the same all-pervading divine consciousness.

The yogi never neglects or mortifies the body or the mind, but cherishes both. To him the body is not an impediment to his spiritual liberation nor is it the cause of its fall, but is an instrument of attainment. He seeks a body strong as a thunderbolt, healthy and free from suffering so as to dedicate it in the service of the Lord for which it is intended. As pointed out in the Mundakopanisad the Self cannot be attained by one without strength, nor through heedlessness, nor without an aim. Just as an unbaked earthen pot dissolves in water the body soon decays. So bake it hard in the fire of yogic discipline in order to strengthen and purify it.

The names of the asanas are significant and illustrate the principle of evolution. Some are named after vegetation like the tree (vrksa) and the lotus (padma); some after insects like the locust (salabha) and the scorpion (vrschika); some after aquatic animals and amphibians like the fish (matsya), the tortoise (kurma), the frog (bheka or manduka) or the crocodile (nakra). There are asanas called after birds like the cock (kukkuta), the heron (baka), the peacock (mayura) and the swan (harinsa). They are also named after quadrupeds like the dog (svana), the horse (vatayana), the camel (ustra). Creatures that crawl like the serpent (bhujanga) are not forgotten, nor is the human embryonic state (garbha-pinda) overlooked. Asanas are named after legendary heroes like Vrabhadra and Hanuman, son of the Wind. ages like Bharadvaja, Kapila, Vasigha and Visvamitra are remembered by having asanas named after them. Some asanas are also called after gods of the Hindu pantheon and some recall the Avatars, of Divine Power.

Definition of Pranayama

“Tasmin sati svasa-prasvasayoh gati-vicchedah pranayamah”

“तस्मिन् सति श्वासप्रश्वासयोर्गतिविच्छेदः प्राणायामः” || 49 || (Given by Maharishi

Patanjali)

The Meaning of Tasmin sati svasa-prasvasayoh gati-vicchedah pranayamah

Tasmin sati: - “Once doing that”

Svasa-prasvasayoh: - “Inhalation and Exhalation”

Gati: - “Normal movements”

Viccheda: - “Interruption”

Pranayama: - “Prana” is Breath. “Ayama” means control.

Pranayama is control of Breath”. “Prana” is Breath or vital energy in the body. On subtle levels prana represents the pranic energy responsible for life or life force, and “ayama” means control. So Pranayama is “Control of Breath”.

Pranayama Just as the word yoga is one of wide import, so also is Prana. Prana means breath, respiration, life, vitality, wind, energy or strength. It also connotes the soul as opposed to the body. The word is generally used in the plural to indicate vital breaths. Ayama means length, expansion, stretching or restraint. Pranayama thus connotes extension of breath and its control. This control is over all the functions of breathing, namely, (1) Inhalation or inspiration, which is termed Puraka (filling up); (2) Exhalation or expiration, which is called rechaka (emptying the lungs), and (3) retention or holding the breath, a state where there is no inhalation or exhalation, which is termed kumbhaka. In Hatha Yoga texts kumbhaka is also used in a loose generic sense to include all the three respiratory processes of inhalation, exhalation and retention.

A kumbha is a pitcher, water pot, jar or chalice. A water pot may be emptied of all air and filled completely with water, or it may be emptied of all water and filled completely with air. Similarly, there are two states of kumbhaka namely (1) when breathing is suspended after full inhalation (the lungs being completely filled with life giving air), and (2) when breathing is suspended after full exhalation (the lungs being emptied of all noxious air). The first of these states, where breath is held after a full inhalation, but before exhalation begins, is known as Antara Kumbhaka. The second, where breath is held after a full exhalation, but before inhalation begins is known as Bahya Kumbhaka. Antara means inner or interior, while Bahya means outer or

exterior. Thus, kumbhaka is the interval or intermediate time between full inhalation and exhalation (Antara Kumbhaka) or between full exhalation and inhalation (Bahya Kumbhaka). In both these types breathing is suspended and restrained.

Pranayama is thus the science of breath. It is the hub round which the wheel of life revolves. As lions, elephants and tigers are tamed very slowly and cautiously, so should Prana be brought under control very slowly in gradation measured according to one's capacity and physical limitations. Otherwise it will kill the practitioner, warns the Hatha Yoga Pradipika (Chapter II, Verse I6).

5. Differences between Asana and Physical Exercise

Asana

- Performing yogic asana is associated with physical, mental and spiritual benefits. It increases flexibility develops a sense of calmness and helps achieve the ultimate goal of nirvana or salvation.
- Asanas are complete and balanced. They work on the whole body. All asanas are practised on both right and left sides along with complementary postures. These make sure that all the muscles of the body are worked equally.
- Asana practice is slow and conscious and done with breath awareness. The goal is to keep the mind at the present moment by concentrating on the breath.
- The body's physiology is altered so that there is a reduced respiratory rate, heart rate and pulse rate with continued asana practice etc.

Physical Exercise

- Physical exercises on the other hand only influence the physical body and the mind. They are not known to be associated with spirituality.
- Exercises may be lopsided, working only on some muscles and neglecting others.
- Exercises are fast and allow jerky movements. Oftentimes the mind is wandering elsewhere while the body slogs to burn those extra calories.
- Exercise is associated with an increased muscle tone, often leading to cramps etc.

6. Asana and Pranayama

(a) Surya Namaskar , (b) Bhujangasana, (c) Naukasana (d) Halasana (e) Vajrasana, (f) Padmasana, (g) Shavasana, (h) Makrasana (i) Dhanurasana, (j) Tadasana

(a) Surya Namaskar

Position 1: Pranamasana (prayer pose)

Keep the eyes closed. Remain standing upright with the feet together. Slowly bend the elbows and place the palms together in front of the chest in namaskara mudra, mentally offering homage to the sun, the source of all life. Relax the whole body. Breathing: Breathe normally.

Awareness: Physical – on the chest area. Spiritual – on anahata chakra.

Mantra: Om Mitraya Namaha, salutations to the friend of all.

Benefits: This pose establishes a state of concentration and calmness in preparation for the practice to be performed.

Position 2: Hasta Utthanasana (raised arms pose)

Raise and stretch both arms above the head. Keep the arms separated, shoulder width apart. Bend the head, arms and upper trunk backward.

Breathing: Inhale while raising the arms.

Awareness: Physical – on the stretch of the abdomen and expansion of the lungs. Spiritual – on vishuddhi chakra.

Mantra: Om Ravaye Namaha, salutations to the shining one.

Benefits: This pose stretches all the abdominal organs and improves digestion. It exercises the arm and shoulder muscles, tones the spinal nerves, opens the lungs and removes excess weight.

Position 3: Padahasthasana (hand to foot pose)

Bend forward until the fingers or palms of the hands touch the floor on either side of the feet. Try to touch the knees with the forehead. Do not strain. Keep the knees straight.

Breathing: Exhale while bending forward. Try to contract the abdomen in the final position to expel the maximum amount of air from the lungs.

Awareness: Physical – on the pelvic region. Spiritual – on swadhisthana chakra. **Mantra:** Om Suryaya Namaha, salutations to he who induces activity.

Contra-indications: People with back conditions should not bend forward fully. Bend from the hips, keeping the spine straight, until the back forms an ninety degree angle with the legs, or bend only as far as comfortable.

Benefits: This pose is useful in eliminating or preventing stomach or abdominal ailments. It reduces excess weight in the abdominal region, improves digestion and helps to remove

constipation. It improves blood circulation, makes the spine supple and tones the spinal nerves.

Position 4: Ashwa Sanchalanasana (equestrian pose)

Place the palms of the hands flat on the floor beside the feet. Stretch the right leg back as far as possible. At the same time, bend the left knee, keeping the left foot on the floor in the same position. Keep the arms straight. In the final position, the weight of the body should be supported on both hands, the left foot, right knee and toes of the right foot. The head should be tilted backward, the back arched and thinner gaze directed upward to the eyebrow center.

Breathing: Inhale while stretching the right leg back.

Awareness: Physical – on the stretch from the thigh to the chest or on the eyebrow center. Spiritual – on ajna chakra.

Mantra: Om Bhanave Namaha, salutations to he who illumines.

Benefits: This pose massages the abdominal organs and improves their functioning, strengthens the leg muscles and induces balance in the nervous system. Practice note: In the final pose the palms of the hands should be flat on the floor initially. Later on, more advanced practitioners may come up onto the fingertips.

Position 5: Parvatasana (mountain pose)

Take the left foot back beside the right foot. Simultaneously, raise the buttocks and lower the head between the arms, so that the back and legs form two sides of a triangle. The legs and arms should be straight in the final position. Try to keep the heels on the floor in the final pose and bring the head towards the knees. Do not strain.

Breathing: Exhale while taking the left leg back.

Awareness: Physical – on relaxing the hips or on the throat region. Spiritual – on vishuddhi chakra.

Mantra: Om Khagaya Namaha, salutations to he who moves quickly in the sky.

Benefits: This pose strengthens the nerves and muscles in the arms and legs. The spinal nerves are toned and circulation is stimulated especially in the upper spine, between the shoulder blades.

Position 6: Ashtanga Namaskara (salute with eight parts or points)

Lower the knees, chest and chin to the floor. In the final position only the toes, knees, chest, hands and chin touch the floor. The knees, chest and chin should touch the floor simultaneously. If this is not possible, first lower the knees, then the chest, and finally the chin. The buttocks, hips and abdomen should be raised.

Breathing: The breath is held outside in this pose. There is no respiration.

Awareness: Physical – on the abdominal region. Spiritual – on manipura chakra.

Mantra: Om Pushne Namaha, salutations to the giver of strength.

Benefits: This pose strengthens the leg and arm muscles, develops the chest and exercises the region of the spine between the shoulder blades.

Position 7: Bhujangasana (cobra pose)

Lower the buttocks and hips to the floor, straightening the elbows, arch the back and push the chest forward into the cobra pose. Bend the head back and direct the gaze upward to the eyebrow center. The thighs and hips remain on the floor and the arms support the trunk. Unless the spine is very flexible the arms will remain slightly bent.

Breathing: Inhale while raising the torso and arching the back. Awareness: Physical – on relaxation of the spine. Spiritual – on swadhisthana chakra.

Mantra: Om Hiranya Garbhaya Namaha, salutations to the golden, cosmic self.

Benefits: This pose keeps the spine supple, improving circulation in the back region and toning the spinal nerves. It tones the reproductive organs, stimulates digestion and relieves constipation. It also tones the liver and massages the kidneys and adrenal glands.

Position 8: Parvatasana (mountain pose)

This stage is a repeat of position 5. From bhujangasana assume parvatasana. The hands and feet do not move from position 7. Raise the buttocks and lower the heels to the floor.

Breathing: Exhale while raising the buttocks.

Awareness: Physical – on relaxing the hips or on the throat region. Spiritual – on vishuddhi chakra.

Mantra: Om Marichaye Namaha, salutations to the Lord of the Dawn.

Position 9: Ashwa Sanchalanasana (equestrian pose)

This stage is the same as position 4. Keep the palms flat on the floor. Bend the left leg and bring the left foot forward between the hands. Simultaneously, lower the right knee so that it touches the floor and push the pelvis forward. Tilt the head backward, arch the back and gaze at the eyebrow center.

Breathing: Inhale while assuming the pose.

Awareness: Physical – on the stretch from the thigh to the chest, or on the eyebrow center. Spiritual- on ajna chakra.

Position 10: Padahasthasana (hand to foot pose)

This position is a repeat of position 3. Bring the right foot forward next to the left foot. Straighten both knees. Bring the forehead as close to the knees as possible without straining.

Breathing: Exhale while performing the movement.

Awareness: Physical – on the pelvic region. Spiritual – on swadhisthana chakra.

Mantra: Om Savitre Namaha, salutations to Lord of Creation.

Position 11: Hasta Utthanasana (raised arms pose)

This stage is a repeat of position 2. Raise the torso and stretch the arms above the head. Keep the arms separated, shoulder width apart. Bend the head, arms and upper trunk backward.

Breathing: Inhale while straightening the body.

Awareness: Physical – on the stretch of the abdomen and expansion of the lungs. Spiritual – on vishuddhi chakra.

Mantra: Om Arkaya Namaha, salutations to he who is fit to be praised.

Position 12: Pranamasana (prayer pose)

This is the final position and is the same as position 1. Bring the palms together in front of the chest.

Breathing: Exhale while assuming the final position.

Awareness: Physical – on the region of the heart. Spiritual – on anahata chakra.

Mantra: Om Bhaskaraya Namaha, salutations to he who leads to enlightenment.

(b) Bhujangasana (cobra pose)

Lie flat on the stomach with the legs straight, feet together and the soles of the feet uppermost. Place the palms of the hands flat on the floor, below and slightly to the side of the shoulders.

The fingers should be together and pointing forward. The arms should be positioned so that the elbows point backward and are close to the sides of the body.

Rest the forehead on the floor and close the eyes.

Relax the whole body, especially the lower back.

Slowly raise the head, neck and shoulders. Straightening the elbows, raise the trunk as high as possible. Use the back muscles more than the arm muscles. Be aware of using the back muscles first while starting to raise the trunk. Then use the arm muscles to raise the trunk further and arch the back. Gently tilt the head backward, so that the chin points forward and the back of the neck is compressed.

In the final position, the pubic bone remains in contact with the floor and the navel is raised a maximum of 3 cm. If the navel is raised too high, the bend tends to be in the knees and not in the back.

The arms may or may not be straight; this will depend on the flexibility of the back. Hold the final position.

To return to the starting position, slowly bring the head forward, release the upper back by bending the arms, lower the navel, chest, shoulders and finally the forehead to the floor. Relax the lower back muscles. This is one round.

Breathing: Inhale while raising the torso. Breathe normally in the final position or retain the breath if the pose is held for a short time. Exhale while lowering the torso.

Duration: Practice up to 5 rounds, gradually increasing the length of time in the final position.

Contra-indications: People suffering from peptic ulcer, hernia, intestinal tuberculosis or hyperthyroidism should not practice this asana without expert guidance.

Benefits: This asana can relocate slipped disc, remove backache and keep the spine supple and healthy. A stiff spine interferes with all nervous impulses sent from the brain to the body and vice versa. By arching the spine, improving circulation in the back region and toning the nerves, better communication between the brain and body results. This asana tones the ovaries and uterus, and helps alleviate menstrual and other gynaecological disorders. It stimulates the appetite, alleviates constipation and is beneficial for all the abdominal organs, especially the liver and kidneys. The adrenal glands, situated on top of the kidneys, are also massaged and stimulated to work more efficiently. The secretion of cortisone is maintained and the thyroid gland is regulated. On a pranic level, bhujangasana has a strong effect on all the organs related to swadhisthana, manipura, anahata and vishuddhi chakras.

(c) Halasana (plough pose)

Lie flat on the back with the legs and feet together. Place the arms beside the body with the palms facing down. Relax the whole body. Raise both legs to the vertical position, keeping them straight and together, using only the abdominal muscles. Press down on the arms and lift the buttocks, rolling the back away from the floor. Lower the legs over the head. Try to touch the toes to the floor behind the head. Do not force the toes to touch the floor. Turn the palms up, bend the elbows and place the hands behind the ribcage to support the back as in sarvangasana. Relax and hold the final pose for as long as is comfortable. Return to the starting position by lowering the arms with the palms facing down, and then slowly lower the back and buttocks to the floor.

Raise the legs to the vertical position. Using the abdominal muscles, lower the legs to the starting position, keeping the knees straight.

Breathing: Inhale while in the lying position. Retain the breath inside while assuming the final pose. Breathe slowly and deeply in the final pose. Retain the breath inside while returning to the starting position.

Duration: Beginners should hold the pose for 15 seconds, gradually adding a few seconds per week until it can be held for one minute. Adept may hold the final pose up to 10 minutes or longer.

Awareness: Physical – on the abdomen, relaxation of the back muscles, the respiration or the thyroid gland. Spiritual - on manipura or vishuddhi chakra.

Contra-indications: This asana should not be practiced by those who suffer from hernia, slipped disc, sciatica, high blood pressure or any serious back problem, especially arthritis of the neck.

Benefits: The movement of the diaphragm which takes place during the practice of halasana massages all the internal organs, activates the digestion, relieving constipation and dyspepsia, revitalizes the spleen and the suprarenal glands, promotes the production of insulin by the pancreas and improves liver and kidney function.

(d) Vajrasana (thunderbolt pose)

Kneel on the floor.

Bring the big toes together and separate the heels. Lower the buttocks on to the inside surface of the feet with the heels touching the sides of the hips. Place the hands on the knees, palms down. The back and head should be straight but not tense. Avoid excessive backward arching of the spine. Close the eyes, relax the arms and the whole body.

Breathe normally and fix the attention on the flow of air passing in and out of the nostrils.

Duration: Practice vajrasana as much as possible, especially directly after meals, for at least 5 minutes to enhance the digestive function. In cases of acute digestive disorder, sit in vajrasana and practice abdominal breathing for 100 breaths before and after food.

Awareness: Physical – on the normal breathing process. These will bring tranquillity to the mind if practiced with the eyes closed. Spiritual – on manipura chakra.

Benefits: Vajrasana alters the flow of blood and nervous impulses in the pelvic region and strengthens the pelvic muscles. It is a preventative measure against hernia and also helps to relieve piles. It increases the efficiency of the entire digestive system, relieving stomach ailments such as hyperacidity and peptic ulcer. It reduces the blood flow to the genitals and massages the nerve fibers which feed them, making it useful in the treatment of dilated

testicles and hydrocele in men. It assists women in lab or and helps alleviate menstrual disorders.

Vajrasana is a very important meditation posture because the body becomes upright and straight with no effort. It is the best meditation asana for people suffering from sciatica and sacral infections. It stimulates the vajra nadi, activates prana in sushumna and redirects sexual energy to the brain for spiritual purposes.

(e) Padmasana (lotus pose)

Sit with the legs straight in front of the body.

Slowly and carefully bend one leg and place the foot on top of the opposite thigh.

The sole should face upward and the heel should be close to the pubic bone. When this feels comfortable, bend the other leg and place the foot on top of the opposite thigh.

Both knees should, ideally, touch the ground in the final position.

The head and spine should be held upright and the shoulders relaxed. Place the hands on the knees in chin or gyana mudra. Relax the arms with the elbows slightly bent and check that the shoulders are not raised or hunched. Close the eyes and relax the whole body.

Observe the total posture of the body. Make the necessary adjustments by moving forward or backward until balance and alignment are experienced. Perfect alignment indicates the correct posture of padmasana.

Contra-indications: Those who suffer from sciatica, sacral infections or weak or injured knees should not perform this asana. This asana should not be attempted until flexibility of the knees has been developed through practice of the pre-meditation asanas.

Benefits: Padmasana allows the body to be held completely steady for long periods of time. It holds the trunk and head like a pillar with the legs as the firm foundation. As the body is steadied the mind becomes calm. This steadiness and calmness is the first step towards real meditation. Padmasana directs the flow of prana from mooladhara chakra in the perineum, to sahasrara chakra in the head, heightening the experience of meditation. This posture applies pressure to the lower spine which has a relaxing effect on the nervous system. The breath becomes slow, muscular tension is decreased and blood pressure is reduced. The coccygeal and sacral nerves are toned as the normally large blood flow to the legs is redirected to the abdominal region. This activity also stimulates the digestive process.

(f) Shavasana (corpse pose)

Lie flat on the back with the arms about 15 cm away from the body, palms facing upward. A thin pillow or folded cloth may be placed behind the head to prevent discomfort. Let the fingers curl up slightly.

Move the feet slightly apart to a comfortable position and close the eyes. The head and spine should be in a straight line.

Make sure the head does not fall to one side or the other. Relax the whole body and stop all physical movement. Become aware of the natural breath and allow it to become rhythmic and relaxed.

Begin to count the breaths from number 27 backwards to zero. Mentally repeat, “I am breathing in 27, I am breathing out 27, I am breathing in 26, I am breathing out 26”, and so on, back to zero.

If the mind wanders and the next number is forgotten, bring it back to the counting and start again at 27. If the mind can be kept on the breath for a few minutes the body will relax.

Duration: According to time available. In general, the longer the better although a minute or two is sufficient between asana practices.

Awareness: Physical – first on relaxing the whole body. Then on the breath and counting. Spiritual – on ajna chakra.

Benefits: This asana relaxes the whole psycho-physiological system. It should ideally be practiced before sleep; before, during and after asana practice, particularly after dynamic exercises such as surya namaskara; and when the practitioner feels physically and mentally tired. It develops body awareness. When the body is completely relaxed, awareness of the mind increases, developing pratyahara.

Note: This asana is also known as mritasana, the dead man’s pose.

(g) Makarasana (crocodile pose)

Lie flat on the stomach.

Raise the head and shoulders and rest the chin in the palms of the hands with the elbows on the floor.

Keep the elbows together for a more pronounced arch to the spine. Separate the elbows slightly to relieve excess pressure on the neck. In makarasana the effect is felt at two points: the neck and the lower back. If the elbows are too far in front, tension will be felt in the neck; if they are drawn too close to the chest, tension will be felt more in the lower back. Adjust the

position of the elbows so that these two points are equally balanced. The ideal position is when the whole spine is equally relaxed. Relax the whole body and close the eyes.

Breathing: Natural and rhythmic.

Duration: For as long as possible.

Benefits: This asana is very effective for people suffering from slipped disc, sciatica, lower back pain or any other spinal disorder. They should remain in this asana for extended periods of time as it encourages the vertebral column to resume its normal shape and releases compression of the spinal nerves. Asthmatics and people who have any other lung ailments should practice this simple asana regularly with breath awareness as it allows more air to enter the lungs.

(h) Saral Dhanurasana (easy bow pose)

Lie flat on the stomach with the legs and feet together, and the arms and hands beside the body. Bend the knees and bring the heels close to the buttocks. Grasp the ankles with the hands. Keep the knees and thighs firmly on the ground and the arms straight throughout the practice. Place the chin on the floor. This is the starting position. Tense the legs and try to push the feet backwards while raising the head and chest as high as possible from the floor. Use the backward movement of the legs to assist the raising of the body, allowing the back muscles to remain passive. In the final position the head is tilted back. Hold the final position for as long as is comfortable. Slowly lower the chest and head to the ground by releasing the legs. Relax in the prone position until the respiration returns to normal. This is one round.

Breathing: Inhale deeply in the starting position. Retain the breath inside while raising the body. Breathe deeply and slowly in the final position. Exhale while returning to the starting position.

Awareness: Physical – on the abdominal or back regions or on deep breathing in the final position. Spiritual – on vishuddhi or anahata chakra.

Benefits: The same as for dhanurasana but at decreased levels. This posture is recommended as therapy for lower back pain due to slipped disc or cervical spondylitis when it can be performed without discomfort. It tones the heart and lungs, and is beneficial for all respiratory disorders.

(i) Tadasana (palm tree pose)

Stand with the feet together or about 10 cm apart, and the arms by the sides.

Steady the body and distribute the weight equally on both feet. Raise the arms over the head. Interlock the fingers and turn the palms upward.

Place the hands on top of the head. Fix the eyes at a point on the wall slightly above the level of the head. The eyes should remain fixed on this point throughout the practice.

Inhale and stretch the arms, shoulders mid chest upward. Raise the heels coming up onto the toes.

Stretch the whole body from top to bottom, without losing balance or moving the feet.

Hold the breath and the position for a few seconds.

At first it may be difficult to maintain balance but with practice it becomes easier. Lower the heels while breathing out and bring the hands the top of the head.

This is one round.

Relax for a few seconds before performing the next round. Practice 5 to 10 rounds.

Breathing: The breath should be synchronized with the raising and lowering of the arms.

Awareness: Physical – on the breathing, maintaining balance and the stretch of the whole body from top to bottom. Spiritual – initially on mooladhara chakra to provide stability; once balance is achieved, change to ajna.

Sequence: Tadasana can be followed by any inverted asana.

Benefits: This asana develops physical and mental balance. The entire spine is stretched and loosened, helping to clear up congestion of the spinal nerves at the points where they emerge from the spinal column. Tadasana stretches the rectus abdomini muscles and the intestines and is useful during the first six months of pregnancy to keep the abdominal muscles and nerves toned.

Pranayama

(1). Anulom Vilom Pranayama

(2). Bhramari Pranayama

Four aspects of pranayama in the pranayama practices there are four important aspects of breathing which are utilized. These are: a) Pooraka or inhalation b) Rechaka or exhalation c) Antar kumbhaka or internal breath retention d) Bahir kumbhaka or external breath retention.

The different practices of pranayama involve various techniques which utilize these four aspects of breathing. There is another mode of pranayama which is called kevala kumbhaka or spontaneous breath retention. This is an advanced stage of pranayama which occurs during high states of meditation. During this state, the lungs stop their activity and the respiration ceases. At this time, the veil which prevents one from seeing the subtle aspect of existence is lifted and a higher vision of reality is attained. The most important part of

pranayama is actually kumbhaka or breath retention. However, in order to perform kumbhaka successfully, there must be a gradual development of control over the function of respiration. Therefore, in the pranayama practices more emphasis is given to inhalation and exhalation at the beginning, in order to strengthen the lungs and balance the nervous and pranic systems in preparation for the practice of kumbhaka. These practices influence the flow of prana in the nadis, purifying, regulating and activating them, thereby inducing physical and mental stability. (For more information on nadis see the chapter Psychic Physiology of Yoga.)

Hand position: Nasagra Mudra (nose tip position)

Hold the fingers of the right hand in front of the face. Rest the index and middle fingers gently on the eyebrow center. Both fingers should be relaxed. The thumb is above the right nostril and the ring finger above the left. These two digits control the flow of breath in the nostrils by alternately pressing on one nostril, blocking the flow of breath, and then the other. The little finger is comfortably folded. When practicing for long periods, the elbow may be supported by the left hand although care is needed to prevent chest restriction.

Nadi Shodhana Pranayama (psychic network purification) (Anulom Vilom)

Technique 1: Preparatory practice Sit in any comfortable meditation posture, preferably siddha/siddha yoniasana or padmasana. (Those who cannot sit in a meditation posture may sit against a wall with the legs outstretched or in a chair which has a straight back). Keep the head and spine upright.

Relax the whole body and close the eyes. Practice yogic breathing for some time. Adopt nasagra mudra with the right hand and place the left hand on the knee in chin or gyana mudra. Close the right nostril with the thumb. Inhale and exhale through the left nostril 5 times. The rate of inhalation/exhalation should be normal. Be aware of each breath. After 5 breaths release the pressure of the thumb on the right nostril and press the left nostril with the ring finger, blocking the flow of air. Inhale and exhale through the right nostril 5 times, keeping the respiration rate normal. Lower the hand and breathe 5 times through both nostrils together. This is one round. Practice 5 rounds or for 3 to 5 minutes, making sure that there is no sound as the air passes through the nostrils. After practicing for 15 days go on to technique 2.

Technique 2: Alternate nostril breathing in this technique the duration of inhalation/exhalation is controlled. Close the right nostril with the thumb and breathe in through the left nostril. At the same time count mentally, “1, Om; 2, Om; 3, Om,” until the

inhalation ends comfortably. This is the basic count. Breathe deeply with yogic breathing. Do not strain. Close the left nostril with the ring finger, release the pressure of the thumb on the right nostril and while breathing, out through the right nostril, simultaneously count, “1, Om; 2, Om; 3, Om.” The time for inhalation and exhalation should be equal. Next, inhale through the right nostril, keeping the same count in the same manner. At the end of inhalation close the right nostril, open the left nostril and exhale through the left nostril, counting as before. This is one round. Practice 10 rounds.

Ratio and timing: After a few days, if there is no difficulty, increase the length of inhalation/exhalation by one count. Continue in this way, increasing the inhalation/exhalation by one count as it becomes easy, until the count of 24:24 is reached. Do not force the breath in any way and be careful not to speed up the counting during exhalation to compensate for shortage of breath. At the slightest sign of discomfort reduce the count. After perfecting the above ratio, it may be changed to 1:2. For example, breathe in for a count of 4 and breathe out for a count of 8 or breathe in for account of 5 and breathe out for a count of 10, up to the count of 12:24. This ratio establishes a calming rhythm for the brain and heart, assisting the treatment of cardiovascular and nervous system disorders specifically, and stress related conditions generally.

Bhramari Pranayama (humming bee breath)

Sit in a comfortable meditation asana. The spinal cord should be erect, the head straight and the hands resting on the knees in chin or gyana mudra. The ideal posture for this practice is padmasana or siddha/ siddha yoni asana. The position of nadanusandhana asana, which is used in nada yoga, may also be utilized as follows. Sit on a rolled blanket with the heels drawn up to the buttocks. Place the feet flat on the floor with the knees raised and the elbows resting on the knees. (For full details refer to Bihar School of Yoga publication Yoga and Kriya). Close the eyes and relax the whole body for a short time.

The lips should remain gently closed with the teeth slightly separated throughout the practice. This allows the sound vibration to be heard and felt more distinctly in the brain. Make sure the jaws are relaxed. Raise the arms sideways and bend the elbows, bringing the hands to the ears. Use the index or middle finger to plug the ears. The flaps of the ears may be pressed without inserting the fingers. If the position of nad anusandhana has been assumed, plug the ears with the thumbs, resting the other four fingers on the head. Bring the awareness to the center of the head, where ajna chakra is located, and keep the body absolutely still. Breathe in through the nose. Exhale slowly and in a controlled manner while

making a deep, steady humming sound like that of the black bee. The humming sound should be smooth, even and continuous for the duration of the exhalation. The sound should be soft and mellow, making the front of the skull reverberate. This is one round. At the end of exhalation, breathe in deeply and repeat the process. Perform 5 rounds.

Duration: 5 to 10 rounds are sufficient in the beginning, and then slowly increase to 10 to 15 minutes. In cases of extreme mental tension or anxiety, or when used to assist the healing process, practice for up to 30 minutes.

Time of practice: The best time to practice is late at night or in the early morning as there are fewer external noises to interfere with internal perception. Practicing at this time awakens psychic sensitivity. However, bhamari may be practiced at any time to relieve mental tension, providing the surroundings are peaceful.

Contra-indications: Bhramari should not be performed while lying down. People suffering from severe ear infections should not practice this pranayama until the infection has cleared up. Those with heart disease must practice without breath retention.

Benefits: Bhramari relieves stress and cerebral tension, alleviating anger, anxiety and insomnia, and reducing blood pressure. It speeds up the healing of body tissue and may be practiced after operations. It strengthens and improves the voice and eliminates throat ailments.